

» WORLD PARA ATHLETICS CHAMPIONSHIPS GAME PLAN



Para stars: Switzerland's Elena Kratter (Women's T63 Long Jump silver) with Germany's Johannes Floors (Men's T64 100m silver) at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, New Delhi. REUTERS

Futuristic blades, vintage designs

The basic design of carbon-fibre blades has barely changed since the 1990s, but rising athleticism is **closing the gap** between para and able-bodied athletes, says former Paralympic champion Heinrich Popow.

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Heads turn when athletes in the T64 categories (for competitors with one or two leg amputations) step onto the track at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium during the Para World Championships. Their prosthetic blades – the iconic “J”-shaped carbon

fibre limbs – gleam in dark black, looking less like body parts and more like high-tech equipment straight out of a science fiction film.

Despite their futuristic appearance, the design itself is decades old.

Four-time Paralympic champion Markus Rehm, popularly known as

“the blade jumper,” is running in New Delhi with an Ossur Flex-Foot Cheetah blade attached to his right leg, amputated below the knee after a wakeboarding accident at 14. Rehm, who holds the world record of 8.72m in the Men's T64 long jump, hopes to push that mark further.

The “Cheetah” was popularised in